

SLICE OF LIFE

Amazon Prime Video's Tamil thriller *Suzhal: The Vortex*; Applause Entertainment's hilarious Kannada production *Humble Politician Nograj*; Tovino Thomas as and in *Minnal Murali*, Netflix's first Malayalam film



Allu Arjun and Vijay Deverakonda as investors and brand ambassadors, stars like Samantha, Nithya Menen, Priyamani and Regina Cassandra featuring in its originals and a weekly dose of new content, aha built a subscriber base of two million. But now it has competition—plenty of it.

Be it Amazon Prime Video or ZEE5, pretty much every major platform has set up shop in Chennai and Hyderabad. They have no choice. As per an EY-FICCI report titled 'Tuning into the Consumer' in March 2022, "OTT platforms desirous of a national reach will require to focus on at least eight to nine languages and each language will require at least eight to ten pieces of content across film and episodic per year." It's why the four southern languages—Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Kannada—are pivotal to the content strategy. In June, Amazon Prime Video dropped its first Tamil original, *Suzhal – The Vortex*, while SonyLIV recently announced a host of Tamil titles it will be releasing.

Disney+ Hotstar is already home to web series in Tamil and Telugu, and even ZEE5 is expanding its regional slate. Netflix, which roped in Mani Ratnam for the anthology *Navarasa* and won hearts with its first Malayalam original film, *Minnal Murali*, last year, is getting into the series space. Applause Entertainment, having already produced Kannada series *Humble Politician Nograj* (Voot Select) with Danish Sait in the titular part and three web series in Tamil, has also got a dedicated office in Chennai "with an eye to upscale its regional content repertoire".

India has an estimated 40 million SVoD (subscriber video-on-demand) users. An estimated 20 per cent of these come from the southern centres. With Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh behind only Maharashtra in average internet consumption, OTT platforms have a captive audience waiting to be served. "They do not have options, for Hindi doesn't cover even 50 per cent of India," says Ashish Golwalkar, head of originals